

Commission proposes EU carbon pricing for flights to Middle East but not US or China

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By Tommaso Lecca · Jul 17, 2026, 12:07 PM · [View in your browser](#)

BRUSSELS — The European Commission today proposed extending the EU's Emissions Trading System (ETS) to international flights heading to destinations within 5,000 kilometers of Frankfurt from 2029.

The proposal — part of a broader review of the EU's carbon market — means that “a flight from Frankfurt to Dubai will be part of the ETS, similar with Istanbul,” a senior EU official told reporters. “But a flight from Frankfurt to Tokyo will not be part of the ETS.”

The aviation tax under the EU's carbon pricing system currently only applies to flights within the European Economic Area (the EU plus Iceland, Liechtenstein and Norway).

Today's decision to only extend it to flights under 5,000 kilometers from Europe came after backlash against extending the ETS to all departing flights, which the official confirmed “has been one of the options.”

That would have applied EU carbon pricing to flights to the United States, India and China — countries that have long threatened retaliation if their airlines are brought under the ETS.

Those countries have been exempted since the Commission introduced a “stop-the-clock” measure in 2012, suspending the application of the ETS to flights to non-European destinations while the U.N.'s Carbon Offsetting and Reduction Scheme for International Aviation (CORSIA) was developed. As part of the ETS review, the Commission assessed whether CORSIA is sufficiently aligned with the Paris Agreement's climate objectives.

Today's proposal maintains the “stop-the-clock” for long-haul flights beyond the new 5,000 km scope, while introducing a review clause requiring a fresh assessment of CORSIA in 2032.

The proposal also extends the ETS exemption to domestic flights to and from the outermost regions of the EU, such as the Canary Islands, until the end of 2035.

Before it becomes law, the proposal must be agreed upon by member countries and the European Parliament.

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